STUDY AID · MATTHEW 3 · EPISODE 3 OF 58

The Voice *in the Wilderness*

Elijah's clothes, Isaiah's voice, and the Father's beloved Son.

▶ Watch on YouTube | Channel: Every Word | 21:02 | LSB references

Full title: The REAL Meaning Behind John the Baptist Is WILD! (Matthew 3). Series: The Gospel of Matthew Every Word (playlist of 58 videos). Study hub · ← Episode 2 (Matthew 2)

FROM THE VIDEO · BACKGROUND (ADDED) · DEBATED · LSB TEXT

01 · FROM THE VIDEO

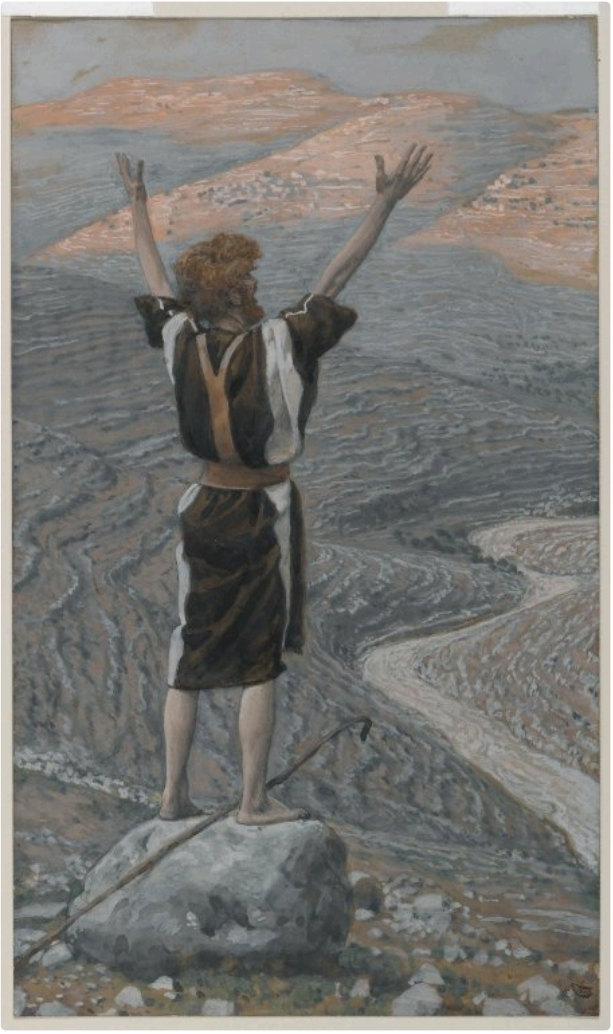
Short summary

- The teacher reads Matthew 3 aloud: John preaching in the wilderness of Judea, his camel's-hair garment and diet, the crowds baptized in the Jordan, his warning to the Pharisees and Sadducees, the promise of One who will baptize with the Holy Spirit and fire, and Jesus' baptism, with the Spirit descending and the Father's voice from heaven.
- As in Matthew 2, Matthew 'replays' Old Testament stories. John (more accurately 'John the baptizer') looks and sounds like Elijah (2 Kings 1:8; Malachi 4:5-6). His birth to old, barren parents, told in Luke 1 rather than Matthew, recalls Abraham and Sarah.
- Many think John was an Essene: the Essenes withdrew to the wilderness of Judea to live out Isaiah 40:3 and practiced a washing tied to repentance. The teacher finds this compelling but says he is undecided.
- Why the wilderness? It is where God speaks and where His people are tested. The video links midbar (wilderness) with davar (speak). John calls Israel out to the wilderness for a new Exodus, to 'develop their ears' to hear the Lord.

> *"We often read these things and we move too quickly past the clues and completely miss what Matthew is telling us.*
>
> From the video (auto-captions, lightly cleaned)

- 'He will baptize you with the Holy Spirit and fire' points to God's new covenant promise to pour out His Spirit (Ezekiel 36:25-27; 39:29; Joel 2:28), which Peter quotes at Pentecost (Acts 2).
- The lesson for the original audience: the new Prophet like Moses and the new Exodus have arrived, because the Messiah has come and His name is Jesus. The lesson for us: be a diligent student of God's Word so you can see the connections.

> ***When something in the New Testament references the old, our radar should bing bing bing bing bing. It should just pop up and start beeping loudly.***
>
> From the video (auto-captions, lightly cleaned)



The voice in the wilderness (3:3)

James Tissot, The Voice in the Desert, 1886-1894. Brooklyn Museum via Wikimedia Commons, public domain



'You brood of vipers' (3:7)

James Tissot, Saint John the Baptist and the Pharisees, 1886-1894. Brooklyn Museum via Wikimedia Commons, public domain

Read it as the first hearers did

The original audience was a community of Jews who had found their Messiah in Jesus, perhaps near Antioch of Syria. They knew the Tanakh, so the teacher asks: why is John **in the desert, dressed in camel's hair, talking about axes, trees and fire?** The answers are in the Old Testament. This is "day three" of his five-day plan: finding a lesson, not the only lesson, for the first hearers and then for us.

The video reads from another English translation. Quotations on this page are from the LSB.

02 · FROM THE VIDEO · LSB TEXT

Scripture passages covered

Each link opens the chapter on read.lsbible.org.

Matthew 3:1-12
John preaches in the wilderness, baptizes in the Jordan, and warns the Pharisees and Sadducees.

Matthew 3:13-17
Jesus is baptized; the heavens open, the Spirit descends like a dove, the Father speaks.

Isaiah 40:1-5
'A voice is calling': prepare the way for Yahweh (quoted in Matthew 3:3).

2 Kings 1:8
Elijah: a hairy man with a leather girdle (compare Matthew 3:4).

Malachi 4:5-6
Elijah the prophet sent before the great and awesome day of Yahweh.

Luke 1
John's birth to Zechariah and Elizabeth, old and barren, like Abraham and Sarah (Genesis 18:11).

Ezekiel 36:25-27; 39:29
Clean water, a new heart, and 'I will put My Spirit within you.'

Joel 2:28-29; Acts 2
'I will pour out My Spirit on all mankind', quoted by Peter at Pentecost.

John 1:35-40
Two of John's disciples follow Jesus.

Hebrews 4:12; 2 Timothy 3:16-17
The word of God is living and active; all Scripture is God-breathed and profitable.

Key verses in the LSB

“Repent, for the kingdom of heaven is at hand.”

Matthew 3:2 (LSB)

“As for me, I baptize you with water for repentance, but He who is coming after me is mightier than I, and I am not fit to remove His sandals; He will baptize you with the Holy Spirit and fire.”

Matthew 3:11 (LSB)

“And behold, there was a voice out of the heavens saying, “This is My beloved Son, in whom I am well-pleased.””

Matthew 3:17 (LSB)

“Behold, I am going to send you Elijah the prophet before the coming of the great and awesome day of Yahweh.”

Malachi 4:5 (LSB)

03 · FROM THE VIDEO LSB TEXT

Old Testament radar: seven voices

"Our radar should bing bing bing." Each card pings as you scroll: the Old Testament voice, then where it sounds in the New. Cards 4 and 7 are added from the LSB margin.

1 Isaiah 40:3 → Matthew 3:3

ISAIAH 40:3 (LSB)

“A voice is calling, / “Prepare the way for Yahweh in the wilderness; / Make smooth in the desert a highway for our God.””

MATTHEW 3:3 (LSB)

“The voice of one crying in the wilderness, / ‘Make ready the way of the Lord, / Make His paths straight!’”

Matthew follows the Greek wording, 'the voice of one crying in the wilderness.' The LSB footnote on 3:3 says 'Lord' here stands for Yahweh in the Old Testament: John prepares the way of Yahweh, and the One who comes is Jesus.

2 2 Kings 1:8 → Matthew 3:4

2 KINGS 1:8 (LSB)

““He was a hairy man with a leather girdle girded about his loins.” And he said, “It is Elijah the Tishbite.””

MATTHEW 3:4 (LSB)

“Now John himself had a garment of camel’s hair and a leather belt around his waist; and his food was locusts and wild honey.”

Same look, same belt. The LSB margin also points to Zechariah 13:4, the prophet's 'hairy mantle.'

3 Malachi 4:5-6 → Matthew 11:14

MALACHI 4:5-6 (LSB)

“Behold, I am going to send you Elijah the prophet before the coming of the great and awesome day of Yahweh. / And he will turn the hearts of the fathers to their children and the hearts of the children to their fathers.”

MATTHEW 11:14 (LSB)

“And if you are willing to accept it, John himself is Elijah who was to come.”

The video reads Malachi 4:5-6. Later in Matthew, Jesus Himself makes the identification (11:14; 17:12-13).

4 Malachi 3:1 → Matthew 11:10 ADDED

MALACHI 3:1 (LSB)

“Behold, I am going to send My messenger, and he will prepare the way before Me. And the Lord, whom you seek, will suddenly come to His temple.”

MATTHEW 11:10 (LSB)

“Behold, I send My messenger ahead of You, / Who will prepare Your way before You.”

In the LSB's word tagging, 'prepare' here is the same Hebrew verb as 'Prepare the way' in Isaiah 40:3 (Strong's H6437). Added link; the video quotes Malachi 4.

5 Ezekiel 36:25-27 → Matthew 3:11

EZEKIEL 36:25-27 (LSB)

“Then I will sprinkle clean water on you, and you will be clean... I will give you a new heart and put a new spirit within you... I will put My Spirit within you.”

MATTHEW 3:11 (LSB)

“He will baptize you with the Holy Spirit and fire.”

The video also reads Ezekiel 39:29: 'I will have poured out My Spirit on the house of Israel.'

6 Joel 2:28 → Acts 2:16-17

JOEL 2:28 (LSB)

“And it will be afterwards / That I will pour out My Spirit on all mankind.”

ACTS 2:16-17 (LSB)

“But this is what was spoken through the prophet Joel: ‘And it shall be in the last days,’ God says, ‘That I will pour out My Spirit on all mankind.’”

Peter quotes Joel at Pentecost, when the Spirit comes with 'tongues as of fire' (Acts 2:3).

7 Psalm 2:7; Isaiah 42:1 → Matthew 3:17 ADDED

PSALM 2:7; ISAIAH 42:1 (LSB)

“He said to Me, ‘You are My Son.’ (Ps 2:7) / Behold, My Servant... My chosen one in whom My soul is well-pleased. I have put My Spirit upon Him. (Isa 42:1)”

MATTHEW 3:17 (LSB)

“This is My beloved Son, in whom I am well-pleased.”

From the LSB margin for 3:17 (not in the video). The voice joins the royal Son of Psalm 2 with the Spirit-filled Servant of Isaiah 42.

> *“The wilderness is a place where people go to hear God speak.*
>
> From the video, on why John is in the desert

Elijah then, John now

The video suggests a Bible study comparing Elijah and John. Here is a start. Left: then. Right: now. Rows marked Added go beyond the video.

THEN	NOW
THEN · 2 KINGS 1:8 Elijah: 'a hairy man with a leather girdle girded about his loins.'	NOW · MATTHEW 3:4 John: 'a garment of camel's hair and a leather belt around his waist.'
THEN · MALACHI 4:5 God promises to send Elijah the prophet before the great and awesome day of Yahweh.	NOW · MATTHEW 3:11 John comes first; the Mightier One comes after him.
THEN · MALACHI 4:6 Elijah will 'turn the hearts of the fathers to their children.'	NOW · MATTHEW 3:6 John preaches repentance, and the people are baptized, confessing their sins. Luke 1:17: he goes 'in the spirit and power of Elijah.'
THEN · GENESIS 18:11 Abraham and Sarah 'were old, advanced in age.' Isaac is born anyway.	NOW · LUKE 1:7 Zechariah and Elizabeth: 'Elizabeth was barren, and they were both advanced in years.'
THEN · 1 KINGS 18:21 Elijah to the crowd on Carmel: 'How long will you be limping between two opinions?'	NOW · MATTHEW 3:8 ADDED John to the Pharisees and Sadducees: 'Therefore bear fruit in keeping with repentance.'
THEN · 2 KINGS 2:8-11 Elijah strikes the Jordan, crosses on dry ground, and is taken up by a whirlwind.	NOW · MATTHEW 3:6, 16 ADDED John baptizes in the Jordan River, and the heavens are opened over Jesus.
THEN · JOSHUA 3:16-17 Israel crosses the Jordan 'opposite Jericho' into the land: the end of the first Exodus.	NOW · MATTHEW 3:5-6 ADDED Crowds go out to the Jordan; the video calls it the time for 'a new Exodus.'

> *The time has come for a new Prophet like Moses, for the new Exodus of God to take place for his people, for the Messiah has arrived and his name is Jesus Christ.*
>
> From the video, the lesson for the original audience

05

Key people and groups

What the video says, then a short background note.

John the Baptist

VIDEO A prophet in the wilderness whose clothes, diet and message replay Elijah. The teacher prefers 'John the baptizer.'

BACKGROUND Son of the priest Zechariah (Luke 1:5, 13). The LSB footnote on 3:1 gives his name as Greek Joannes, Hebrew Johanan. Josephus also records his preaching and his death at Machaerus.

Luke 1 | John 1

Pharisees

VIDEO They come to John's baptism and are called a 'brood of vipers.' The video says they will become very important later in Matthew.

BACKGROUND A lay movement devoted to the Law and the 'tradition of the elders' (Matthew 15:2). They believed in the resurrection and angels (Acts 23:8).

Matthew 23

Sadducees

VIDEO Rebuked alongside the Pharisees; John warns them that judgment is coming.

BACKGROUND Linked with the priestly leadership and the temple. They denied the resurrection (Matthew 22:23). The two groups often disagreed, so Matthew pairing them is striking.

Matthew 22 | Acts 23

The Essenes

VIDEO Many think John was one: they withdrew to the wilderness of Judea to fulfill Isaiah 40:3, and their washing was tied to repentance.

BACKGROUND A strict Jewish group described by Josephus, Philo and Pliny. Most scholars link them with the Qumran community by the Dead Sea. They are never named in the New Testament.

Isaiah 40

Elijah

VIDEO The prophet John 'sounds an awful lot like.' Malachi promised he would come before the day of the Lord.

BACKGROUND The Tishbite (2 Kings 1:8), prophet in the northern kingdom in the 9th century BC. He crossed the Jordan and was taken up by a whirlwind (2 Kings 2:8-11).

2 Kings 1 | 2 Kings 2

Zechariah and Elizabeth

VIDEO John's old, barren parents, a replay of Abraham and Sarah. Their story is in Luke 1, not Matthew.

BACKGROUND Zechariah was a priest 'of the division of Abijah'; Elizabeth was 'from the daughters of Aaron' (Luke 1:5). Luke 1:36 calls Elizabeth Mary's 'relative.'

Luke 1 | Genesis 18

Jesus

VIDEO Comes from Galilee to be baptized. The Spirit descends and the Father speaks: all the persons of the Trinity are present.

BACKGROUND John tries to stop Him; Jesus answers, 'Permit it at this time; for in this way it is fitting for us to fulfill all righteousness' (3:15).

Matthew 3 | John 1



'Permit it at this time' (3:15)

James Tissot, The Baptism of Jesus, 1886-1894. Brooklyn Museum via Wikimedia Commons, public domain



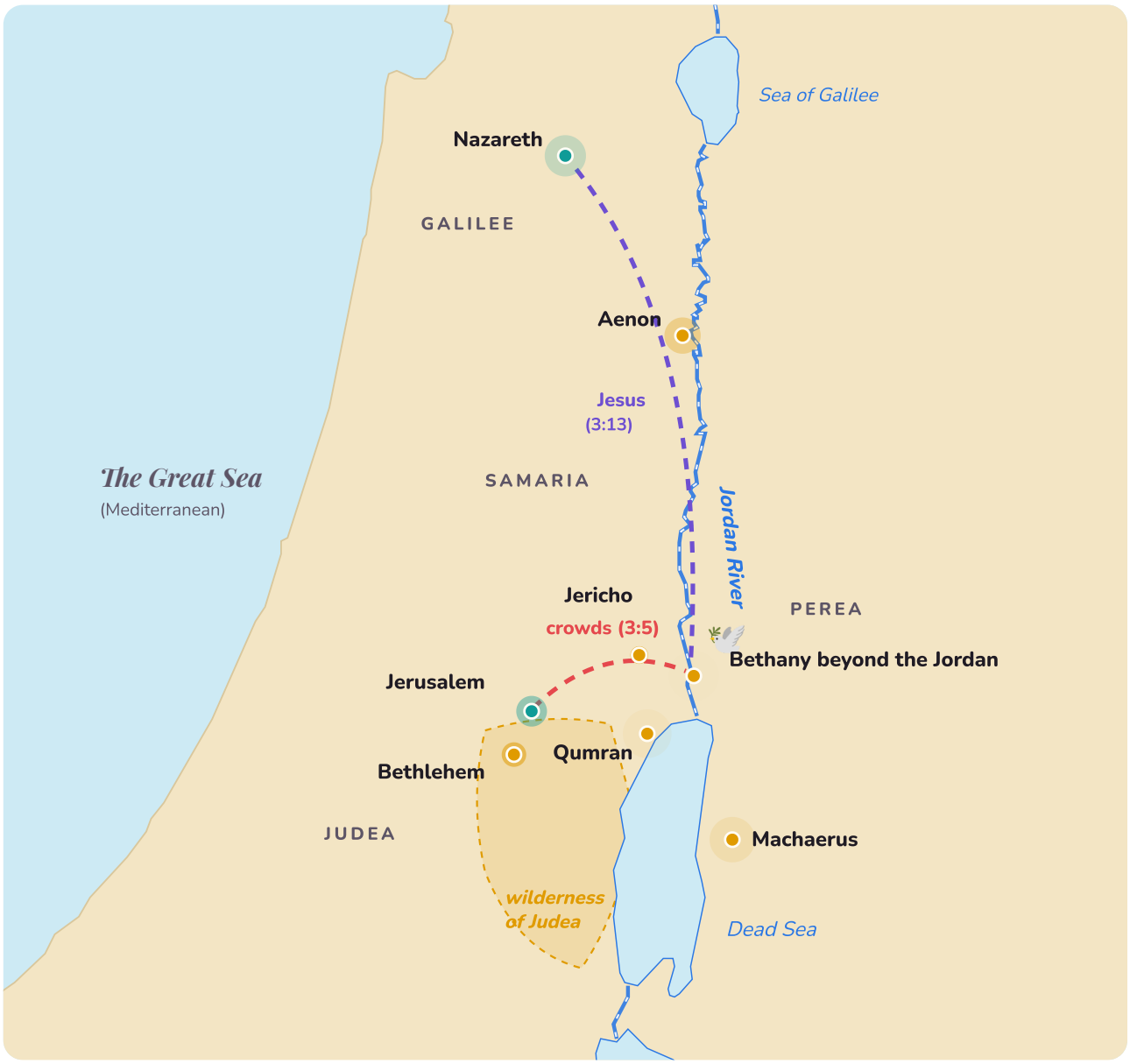
The Spirit descending like a dove (3:16)

Piero della Francesca, The Baptism of Christ, after 1451. National Gallery, London, via Wikimedia Commons, public domain

06 · BACKGROUND MAP

Down to the Jordan

Teal pins are places the video names; gold pins are background. The shaded area is the wilderness of Judea. Routes are schematic.



Crowds from Jerusalem and Judea (3:5) — Jesus from Galilee to the Jordan (3:13) — Wilderness of Judea (approximate)

Positions approximate. Coastlines, lakes and rivers: Natural Earth (public domain). Matthew names only 'the Jordan River'; the baptism site and Jesus' road are not given.

Jerusalem VIDEO
'Jerusalem was going out to him, and all Judea' (3:5)

Bethlehem BACKGROUND
Jesus' birthplace (Matthew 2), at the edge of the wilderness

Jericho BACKGROUND
Israel crossed the Jordan 'opposite Jericho' (Joshua 3:16)

Bethany beyond the Jordan BACKGROUND
Where John was baptizing (John 1:28); traditional site near Jericho, exact location debated

Qumran BACKGROUND
Community often identified as Essenes; the video's Essene discussion

Machaerus BACKGROUND
Herod Antipas' fortress where Josephus says John was killed (Matthew 14)

Nazareth VIDEO
Jesus 'arrived from Galilee at the Jordan' (3:13)

Aenon BACKGROUND
'Aenon near Salim', another place John baptized (John 3:23); location debated

07

Key terms

Repent
BACKGROUND

To turn, to change one's mind and direction. John and Jesus open with the same words: 'Repent, for the kingdom of heaven is at hand' (3:2; 4:17).

Kingdom of heaven
VIDEO

Matthew's usual phrase. The video: 'heaven' here is another way of saying God. Mark 1:15 has 'the kingdom of God.' The LSB footnote on 'at hand': 'Lit has come near.'

Old Testament radar
VIDEO

The video's name for learning the Old Testament so well that New Testament echoes start 'beeping loudly.'

Tanakh
VIDEO

The Hebrew Bible, our Old Testament. The video says Matthew's first hearers should have known it well.

Baptism
BACKGROUND

Immersion or washing in water. John's was 'for repentance' (3:11), with the people 'confessing their sins' (3:6).

Brood of vipers
BACKGROUND

Literally offspring of snakes. Jesus uses the same words for the Pharisees (12:34; 23:33).

Winnowing fork and chaff
BACKGROUND

Grain was tossed in the wind on a threshing floor: heavy wheat fell, light chaff blew away and was burned. A picture of judgment (3:12; Psalm 1:4).

Locusts and wild honey
BACKGROUND

Wilderness food. Leviticus 11:22 lists the locust among clean insects Israel may eat.

Day of Yahweh
VIDEO

The video: the coming of God in both judgment and restoration, fulfilled in Jesus' ministry, death and resurrection.

08 · BACKGROUND

Hebrew and Greek words

The video makes one word point: midbar (wilderness) and davar (speak). The rest are added. Strong's numbers match the LSB's own word tagging for each verse listed.

μετανοέω

metanoeō `G3340`

To repent, change one's mind; in the Gospels, a turn of the whole life toward God.

Greek · Matt 3:2; 4:17

μετάνοια

metanoia `G3341`

Repentance. 'Bear fruit in keeping with repentance' (3:8).

Greek · Matt 3:8, 11

βαπτίζω

baptizō `G907`

To baptize, dip, immerse, wash.

Greek · Matt 3:6, 11, 13-16

ἔρημος

erēmos `G2048`

Wilderness, desert; a lonely, uninhabited place.

Greek · Matt 3:1, 3

ἀκρίς

akris `G200`

Locust, grasshopper.

Greek · Matt 3:4

πνεῦμα

pneuma `G4151`

Spirit, wind, breath. 'The Holy Spirit' (3:11); 'the Spirit of God' (3:16).

Greek · Matt 3:11, 16

δικαιοσύνη

dikaiosynē `G1343`

Righteousness: what is right in God's sight. 'To fulfill all righteousness' (3:15).

Greek · Matt 3:15

ἀγαπητός

agapētos `G27`

Beloved, dearly loved. 'My beloved Son' (LSB footnote: or 'My Son, the Beloved').

Greek · Matt 3:17; 17:5

מִדְבָּר

midbar `H4057`

Wilderness, steppe, pasture land. The LSB tags Isaiah 40:3 as H4057b.

Hebrew · Isa 40:3

דָּבַר

dabar (davar) `H1696`

To speak. Shares the letters d-b-r with midbar, the video's wordplay (see Careful reading).

Hebrew · Isa 40:2 ('Speak')

קוֹל

qol `H6963`

Voice, sound. 'A voice is calling.'

Hebrew · Isa 40:3

שׁוּב

shuv `H7725`

To turn, return; a key Old Testament word for repentance.

Hebrew · Mal 4:6 ('turn')

רוּחַ

ruach `H7307`

Spirit, wind, breath. 'I will put My Spirit within you.'

Hebrew · Ezek 36:27; Joel 2:28; Isa 42:1

רָצָה

ratsah `H7521`

To be pleased with, accept favorably. 'In whom My soul is well-pleased.'

Hebrew · Isa 42:1

Historical and cultural background

ESTABLISHED

Facts most interpreters agree on

The wilderness of Judea

The dry hill country that drops east from Jerusalem and Bethlehem to the Dead Sea and the Jordan valley. The LSB margin for 3:1 points to Joshua 15:61 and Judges 1:16. Luke 1:80 says John 'lived in the desolate regions until the day of his public appearance to Israel.'

Where John baptized

Matthew says 'the Jordan River' (3:6). John's Gospel names 'Bethany beyond the Jordan' (John 1:28) and later 'Aenon near Salim' (John 3:23). The traditional site lies near Jericho, close to where Israel crossed 'opposite Jericho' (Joshua 3:16) and where Elijah crossed before he was taken up (2 Kings 2:6-11).

When

Luke dates the start of John's ministry to 'the fifteenth year of the reign of Tiberius Caesar' (Luke 3:1), usually reckoned about AD 28-29.

Pharisees and Sadducees together

The two parties disagreed on much, including the resurrection (Acts 23:6-8). Matthew pairs them here and again in 16:1-12, where both come to test Jesus.

Children of Abraham

'We have Abraham for our father' (3:9) was a claim to belong to God's covenant people by birth. John says God can raise up children to Abraham 'from these stones'; Paul later says those who belong to Christ are Abraham's seed (Galatians 3:29).

SOURCED

Early witnesses

> *John, that was called the Baptist... was a good man, and commanded the Jews to exercise virtue, both as to righteousness towards one another, and piety towards God, and so to come to baptism.*

Josephus, Jewish historian, c. AD 93. Antiquities of the Jews 18.5.2 (18.116-117), William Whiston translation. He adds that Herod Antipas had John killed at the fortress of Machaerus.

> *He was born and baptized, that by His passion He might purify the water.*

Ignatius of Antioch, c. AD 110. Letter to the Ephesians 18, Ante-Nicene Fathers translation (Roberts and Donaldson).

DEBATED

Where scholars differ

Was John an Essene?

For: John lived in the same wilderness near Qumran; Qumran's Community Rule also applies Isaiah 40:3 to its life in the wilderness; both linked washing with turning from sin; John came from a priestly family. Against: Qumran's washings were repeated and for members, while John's baptism was offered to all Israel; John preached to crowds, tax collectors and soldiers (Luke 3:10-14); no ancient source calls him an Essene. Many scholars allow contact or influence but see membership as unproven.

'The Holy Spirit and fire'

One view: a single baptism, the Spirit who purifies like fire (compare Acts 2:3). Another: two outcomes, the Spirit for the repentant and the fire of judgment for the unrepentant, since fire in 3:10 and 3:12 is judgment. Both views are held by careful interpreters.

Why was the sinless Jesus baptized?

Jesus says it is fitting 'to fulfill all righteousness' (3:15). Proposals that often overlap: He identifies with the sinners He came to save, obeys His Father's plan, and is publicly marked out as the Son (Psalm 2:7) and the Spirit-anointed Servant (Isaiah 42:1). Historic Christian teaching agrees He had no sin of His own to confess (Hebrews 4:15).

Was John Elijah?

Jesus says 'John himself is Elijah who was to come' (Matthew 11:14), yet John told the priests 'I am not' (John 1:21). The usual answer: John is not Elijah returned in person, but comes 'in the spirit and power of Elijah' (Luke 1:17) to fulfill Malachi's promise.

CAREFUL READING

Small slips in the video

Small slips worth knowing (offered gently; the video's main points stand):

- The captions have the video citing '2 Kings 8' for Elijah's clothing. The verse is 2 Kings 1:8; the captions may have dropped the '1'.
- The video says John 'literally quotes from Isaiah 40' in Matthew 3:3. In Matthew it is the narrator who applies Isaiah 40:3 to John ('For this is the one referred to by Isaiah the prophet'). John says it of himself in John 1:23.
- Midbar and davar share the letters d-b-r, so the link is a real wordplay and a memorable picture. Standard Hebrew lexicons (BDB, for example) do not derive 'wilderness' from 'speak'; they connect it with land where flocks are driven to pasture. Treat it as a sermon picture, not an etymology.
- The video calls Jesus 'John's cousin.' Luke 1:36 calls Elizabeth Mary's 'relative'; 'cousin' is a common tradition, but Scripture does not say exactly how they were related.
- The suggestion that Jesus may have been an Essene goes beyond the evidence, and the teacher says he is undecided. Unlike the separatist Qumran community, Jesus ate with tax collectors and sinners (Matthew 9:10-11), and His authority comes from the Father's own word: 'This is My beloved Son' (3:17).
- Caption error, not the teacher's: the auto-captions print 'quenchable fire.' Matthew 3:12 says 'unquenchable fire.'

10 · BACKGROUND

From Elijah to the Jordan

Coral dots mark where Matthew 3 quotes or echoes the event. Early dates are approximate; dates tagged debated vary among scholars.

PATRIARCHAL ERA

Isaac is born to Abraham and Sarah in their old age

Genesis 18 *Echo: Luke 1:7*

C. 1406 OR 13TH CENTURY BC DEBATED

Israel crosses the Jordan 'opposite Jericho' into the land

Joshua 3

9TH CENTURY BC

Elijah, the hairy man with a leather girdle; taken up after crossing the Jordan

2 Kings 1-2 *Echo: Matthew 3:4*

C. 700 BC DEBATED

Isaiah: 'A voice is calling, Prepare the way for Yahweh'

Isaiah 40 *Quoted: Matthew 3:3*

6TH CENTURY BC

Ezekiel: clean water, a new heart, 'My Spirit within you'

Ezekiel 36 *Echo: Matthew 3:11*

C. 5TH CENTURY BC

Malachi: My messenger will prepare the way; Elijah before the day of Yahweh

Malachi 4 *Fulfilled: Matthew 11:10, 14*

C. 2ND CENTURY BC - AD 68 DEBATED

A strict community lives at Qumran by the Dead Sea (often identified as Essenes)

Isaiah 40

C. AD 28-29 DEBATED

'The fifteenth year of Tiberius': John preaches; Jesus is baptized

Luke 3 *Matthew 3*

C. AD 30 OR 33 DEBATED

Pentecost: the Spirit is poured out, as Joel promised

Acts 2 *Fulfills 3:11*

II

Cross-references

LSB cross-references come from the LSB's own margin for Matthew 3; the rest are added.

Mark 1:3-8; Luke 3:2-17; John 1:19-28
Parallel accounts of John's ministry (for 3:1-12)
LSB CROSS-REF

Matthew 11:11-14; 16:14
John and Elijah (for 3:1)
LSB CROSS-REF

Matthew 4:17; Mark 1:15
Jesus preaches the same message (for 3:2)
LSB CROSS-REF

Isaiah 40:3; John 1:23
The voice in the wilderness (for 3:3)
LSB CROSS-REF

2 Kings 1:8; Zechariah 13:4
A prophet's hairy garment (for 3:4)
LSB CROSS-REF

Leviticus 11:22
Locusts are clean food (for 3:4)
LSB CROSS-REF

Matthew 12:34; 23:33
'Brood of vipers' again (for 3:7)
LSB CROSS-REF

John 8:33, 39; Galatians 3:29
Who are Abraham's children? (for 3:9)
LSB CROSS-REF

Acts 2:3-4; Titus 3:5
Spirit and fire; washing and renewal (for 3:11)
LSB CROSS-REF

Psalm 1:4; Isaiah 66:24; Mark 9:43, 48
Chaff and unquenchable fire (for 3:12)
LSB CROSS-REF

Psalm 40:7-8; John 4:34
Doing the Father's will (for 3:15)
LSB CROSS-REF

Psalm 2:7; Isaiah 42:1; Matthew 17:5
My beloved Son (for 3:17)
LSB CROSS-REF

Ezekiel 36:25-27; Joel 2:28-29
The promised outpouring of the Spirit
ADDED

Malachi 3:1; Luke 1:17
The messenger in the spirit and power of Elijah
ADDED

2 Kings 2:6-11
Elijah at the Jordan
ADDED

John 1:29-34
John's own testimony about the dove and the Son
ADDED

12

Reflection and discussion

1. Test your Old Testament radar: read Matthew 3 slowly and list every phrase that rings an Old Testament bell. Which one surprised you?

2. Compare 2 Kings 1:8 and Malachi 4:5-6 with Matthew 3:4 and 11:14. What would it tell Matthew's Jewish hearers that John comes dressed like Elijah?

3. John warns the leaders not to lean on 'We have Abraham for our father' (3:9). What might we lean on instead of real repentance? What would 'fruit in keeping with repentance' (3:8) look like for you this week?

4. At the Jordan the Son is baptized, the Spirit descends and the Father speaks (3:16-17). How does seeing the Trinity here shape the way you pray?

5. The video's question: will you be a diligent student of God's Word? What one change to your reading this week would help you hear Him, even in a 'wilderness' season?

13

Application

FROM THE VIDEO

The video's lesson for the original audience: through John's unique clothes, activities and speech, Matthew shows that the time has come for the new Prophet like Moses and the new Exodus, because the Messiah has arrived and His name is Jesus Christ. Only those who are diligent to see the connections to the Tanakh will fully understand. The same lesson is posed to us: will we lean in and become diligent students of God's Word? The teacher asks

STUDY NOTE (ADDED)

John's first words and Jesus' first words are the same: 'Repent, for the kingdom of heaven is at hand' (3:2; 4:17). Repentance is more than a feeling; it bears fruit (3:8). And the One John announces is more than a greater prophet: Matthew applies Isaiah's 'way of Yahweh' to Jesus' coming, and the Father names Him 'My beloved Son' (3:17). The sinless One stepped into the water beside sinners 'to fulfill all

viewers to follow his five-day plan and share the lesson for their own life.

righteousness', and then went into the wilderness to be tested for them (4:1).

> ***Will you be a diligent student of God's word so that you can understand?***
>
> **From the video. Next time: Matthew 4, Jesus in the wilderness with Satan.**

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